YAOTIAN (JUSTIN) ZHANG

Department of Economics, University of Nebraska–Lincoln, Lincoln, NE 68588, USA
+1 (402) 610-2826 | jzhang113@huskers.unl.edu | justinyzhang.github.io | github.com/justinyzhang

EDUCATION

University of Nebraska–Lincoln — Lincoln, NE, USA
Ph.D. in Economics — 2026–present (expected 2031)

University of Macau — Macau, China
B.Sc. in Economics — 2020–2024

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Fields: Labor Economics, Public Economics, Urban and Spatial Economics, Economics of Education
Topics: College admission and place-based policy; migration and location choice; spatial allocation of human capital
Methods: Quasi-experimental designs; spatial econometrics and GIS; structural models of location choice

RESEARCH

"Green Borders: Cross-Border Enforcement Spillovers from Cannabis Legalization"
Working paper. Illinois opened an adult-use cannabis market in 2020 while neighboring Iowa retained prohibition. Using incident-based crime records for all Iowa counties, I find that counties connected to Illinois by a highway bridge recorded more drug and property offenses after the market opened, with effects that attenuate with distance from the Illinois population. Revenue accounting confined within state lines is therefore likely to understate the cost of legalization.

"Place-Based College Admission and the Geography of Graduates: Evidence from China"
In progress.

"Big Fish, Small Pond, Far Away: High School Rank and Adult Migration"
In progress.

"Admission Policy and the Spatial Allocation of Talent: A Dynamic Model of College and Location Choice"
In progress.

"Disappearing First Rungs: Generative AI, Entry-Level Jobs, and the Geography of Career Ladders"
In progress.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Bureau of Business Research, University of Nebraska–Lincoln — 2026–present
Graduate Research Assistant to Eric Thompson

- Measure skills gaps and education–occupation mismatch across Nebraska labor markets using ACS microdata.

Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Macau — 2023–2024
Research Assistant

- Collected and cleaned data on online political content; replicated machine learning workflows in R.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Teaching Assistant, Graduate Workshops on Causal Inference and Research Methods — Summer 2025
Hong Kong Metropolitan University

Teaching Assistant, Introductory R Programming — Spring 2024
Lui Che Woo College, University of Macau

Fellowships and Awards

Carpenter Fellowship, College of Business, University of Nebraska–Lincoln	2026
Graduate Research Assistantship, Department of Economics, University of Nebraska–Lincoln	2026–2027
Dean's Honour List (top 10%), Faculty of Social Sciences, University of Macau	2023, 2024

Skills

Programming: R, Stata, Python, LaTeX, ArcGIS
Languages: Mandarin Chinese (native), English (fluent)

References

Available upon request.